



SEASON 2026/27 · OFFICIAL DOCUMENT

REGULATION

BALKAN HOCKEY CHAMPIONSHIP

VERSION v3 (draft · 14 September 2026) — updated list of participants with an open fifth place, game rounds once a month, venue of each round set by the calendar, roster additions until the last round, player documents due by the player's first game, play-off format for five teams, English as the official language, third-place game, admission of a fifth team by the Board of Directors

STATUS working document for approval by the Team Representatives Council

Basic principle. All BHC games are played under the current **IIHF Official Rule Book 2025/26** (the official playing rules: rink markings, offside, icing, penalty mechanics, goaltender actions, etc.). This Regulation **does not rewrite** the playing rules; it only sets out the tournament structure, team eligibility and registration, discipline, officiating and organisational procedures, and **league-specific deviations** from the IIHF rules. In everything not covered below, the IIHF Rule Book applies.

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1. GENERAL PROVISIONS

1.1. The Balkan Hockey Championship (hereinafter the **League, BHC**) is an international ice hockey championship with a centralised format. The League's home arena is in **Sarajevo** (Bosnia and Herzegovina). The arena of each game round is stated in the season calendar.

1.2. Season 2026/27: the regular season and the play-offs are held **from October 2026 to January 2027**. The season is played in game rounds: roughly once a month the teams gather for several days and play several games in a row (clause 4.1). The exact dates and venue of each round are set by the season calendar — a separate document published **in the second half of September 2026**, which from that moment becomes an appendix to this Regulation.

1.3. Season participants: **IH Pro Stars** (Novi Sad, Serbia), **Wolves** (Belgrade, Serbia), **Vukovi** (Sarajevo, Bosnia and Herzegovina), **Bulgaria Select** (Sofia, Bulgaria). **The fifth place remains open until the start of the tournament.** The decision to admit a fifth team is made by the League's Board of Directors. If a fifth team is admitted, the calendar and the play-off format (Section 8) apply in their five-team version.

1.4. The official language of the League is English. The Russian edition of this Regulation is a working document; the official English edition is published by the League. In case of discrepancy between the editions, the English edition prevails.

1.5. Interpretation of this Regulation and resolution of matters not covered by it fall within the competence of the League Commissioner together with the Team Representatives Council.

2. LEAGUE GOVERNANCE

2.1. League Commissioner. Strategy, budget, partners, final decisions on disputed matters, approval of the calendar and of officiating crews.

2.2. Team Representatives Council. One representative from each team. Discussion of the format, calendar and organisational matters; voting on amendments to the Regulation (simple majority; in case of a tie, the Commissioner has the casting vote).

2.3. Disciplinary Committee (DC). One representative from each team. Reviews: major (5-minute) penalties and match penalties, suspensions, fights, abuse of officials, protests. A representative does not vote on cases involving his or her own team. DC decisions — see Section 9.

2.4. Head Referee Coordinator. Assignment of referees, liaison with officiating crews, quality control, post-game reports.

3. ELIGIBILITY AND TEAM REGISTRATION

3.1. Team registration. A team submits to the League's sports office:

- a registration form (roster) with the full name, date of birth, position and jersey number of each player;
- a contact person (manager/captain) and a representative on the Council;
- confirmation of medical clearance and insurance (see clause 3.7).

3.1.1. Registration deadlines. By **30 September 2026** a team submits a **minimum registration of 11 players** (10 skaters + a goaltender). The minimum registration and payment of the fee by the deadline announced by the League are conditions of the team's admission to the tournament. The team forms its **main roster** before the start of the championship. **Roster additions are allowed until the last round of the regular season** (clause 3.6) and are **free of charge**: the team fee does not depend on the size of the roster. The roster limit is 30 players (clause 3.4).

3.1.2. Eligibility of a newly added player. A player added to the roster may take the ice once the full set of his or her documents (registration form, assumption-of-risk waiver, parental consent for players aged 16–17, confirmation of medical clearance and insurance) has been delivered to the League secretariat **by the player's first game** — before the game sheet of that game is signed. Without these documents the player is not entered on the game sheet.

3.2. Player level — season 2026/27. In the first season **there are NO restrictions on player level**: a team may field both amateur players and professionals (current and former). The goal of the first season is to build a viable tournament and fill the rosters. A limit on professionals or a "strength cap" may be introduced in future seasons by decision of the Council.

3.3. Age. The minimum age of a player is **16 years** on the date of the first game. **There is no upper age limit.** For players aged **16–17**, the player's documents (clause 3.1) **must include written consent of the parents/guardians** to take part in the League; without this document the player is not admitted to games.

3.4. Roster size.

- **Minimum team registration for the season: 11 players** — 10 skaters + 1 goaltender. A team with a smaller roster is not admitted to the season.
- Team season roster: up to **30 players** (skaters + goaltenders).
- Game roster (dressed): up to **20 skaters + 2 goaltenders** (IIHF guideline).
- **Minimum to start a game: 5 skaters + 1 goaltender** of one team. With fewer players — see clause 11.2 (no-show / forfeit).

3.5. One player — one team. During the season a player is registered with and plays for one team only. A transfer between BHC teams within the season is possible only during the roster-addition period (clause 3.6) and with the consent of both teams and the League.

3.6. End of roster additions. Roster additions and transfers (clauses 3.1.1, 3.5) end after the last round of the regular season; the date is stated in the season calendar. No new players are registered for the play-offs. A player must have played at least **1 regular-season game** for the team to be eligible for the play-offs.

3.7. Medical care and insurance. Every player must hold valid **sports insurance** and confirm the absence of medical contraindications. At game rounds the League provides a doctor/paramedic, first-aid kits and an emergency protocol, but does **not** insure players and is not liable for injuries if a player has no insurance.

3.8. Equipment. The League plays **body-checking hockey** (clause 7.1), so a full set of IIHF-certified protective equipment is **mandatory**: helmet with chin strap, shoulder pads, elbow pads, shin guards, gloves, protective cup, mouthguard (**strongly recommended**). A visor/face mask is **strongly recommended** for all skaters and **mandatory** for players under 18. Goaltenders — full goaltender equipment. A player without the mandatory equipment is not admitted to the game.

3.9. Uniforms. Each team has a set of dark and light jerseys (or contrasting ones). In case of a colour clash, **the team listed as the "visiting" team on the game sheet changes jerseys**; if the status is equal, the team placed lower in the standings changes. Jersey numbers are unique within a team.

4. COMPETITION FORMAT AND STANDINGS

4.1. Regular season. Round-robin format: each pair of teams meets **an equal number of times**, and all teams play **the same number of games**. The number of meetings and games is set by the season calendar and depends on the number of participants (4 or 5).

Games are grouped into **game rounds**: roughly once a month the teams gather for several days and play several games in a row. The dates and arena of each round are given in the season calendar.

The regular season runs from October 2026 to January 2027; the season ends with the play-offs in January (clause 8.1).

4.1.1. Two games in one day. Within a game round, a team may play **two games on the same day** if the season calendar provides for it. The break between the end of the first game and the start of the second is **at least 60 minutes**.

4.2. Points (IIHF 3-2-1-0 system):

RESULT	POINTS
Win in regulation time	3
Win in overtime/shootout	2
Loss in overtime/shootout	1
Loss in regulation time	0

There are no draws in the regular season — if the score is tied after the 3rd period, overtime and, if necessary, a shootout are played (Section 6).

4.3. Standings. One table for all teams. Places are determined by the **total number of points**. If teams are level on points, the tie-breakers of Section 10 apply.

Every game of a team always receives a result: a game that did not take place is either rescheduled or recorded as a forfeit (clause 11.5). Therefore by the end of the season all teams have played the same number of games, and the points total is a fair measure.

4.3.1. The published standings show: games played, wins and losses (separately in regulation and in overtime/shootout), goals for and against, goal difference and points.

4.4. Qualification for the play-offs. Based on the results of the regular season (Section 8).

5. GAME REGULATIONS

5.1. Duration. A game consists of **3 periods of 20 minutes of stop time** — the IIHF standard; a game takes about 2:00–2:15 and fits into the ice slot. Intermissions between periods — **5 minutes**.

5.2. Ice resurfacing / scraping. On days with several games in a row, full resurfacing is carried out according to the League schedule; between periods a **dry scrape** is allowed to save slot time. The exact resurfacing schedule is published for each game round.

5.3. Players on the ice. 5 skaters + a goaltender for each team (at even strength). Line changes on the fly according to IIHF rules.

5.4. Time-outs. Each team has **1 time-out of 30 seconds** per game (in regulation time; in overtime — according to IIHF rules).

5.5. Warm-up. The pre-game warm-up follows the slot schedule (usually 3–5 minutes); with a tight schedule it may be shortened or cancelled by decision of the League.

5.6. Late arrival / not ready. A team must be ready for the opening face-off on schedule. For delaying the start of a game — see clause 11.3.

5.7. Game sheet. Kept by the League secretary: line-ups, goals and assists, penalties, goaltenders, final score, times. Captains/coaches sign the final game sheet. Claims regarding the game sheet — no later than 15 minutes after the final siren (otherwise the result is considered accepted).

6. OVERTIME AND SHOOTOUT (REGULAR SEASON)

6.1. Overtime. If the score is tied after the 3rd period — **5 minutes of 3-on-3 overtime**, until the first goal (sudden death), after a short break. Penalty mechanics in overtime — according to IIHF rules (line-ups may temporarily increase to 4-on-4 / 4-on-3).

6.2. Shootout. If no goal is scored in overtime — a shootout under the IIHF procedure: **3 different players** from each team shoot alternately; if still tied — sudden-death rounds with one shooter each (players may be repeated), with the shooting order reversed.

6.3. Points. The winner in overtime/shootout receives **2 points**, the loser — **1** (clause 4.2).

6.4. Play-offs — a different overtime format: see clause 8.5 (there can be no draws; play continues until a goal).

7. CONTACT, SAFETY AND PENALTIES

7.1. Level of contact — BODY-CHECKING HOCKEY (full contact under IIHF rules). Body checking is **allowed** under the IIHF Official Rule Book. Given the mixed rosters (amateurs + professionals, clause 3.2), special emphasis is placed on clean checks and on protecting players in a vulnerable position; equipment under clause 3.8 is mandatory.

- **Allowed:** a body check under IIHF rules against the player in possession of the puck or the last player to have possessed it — with the body / shoulder / hip, without any of the infractions listed below.
- **Prohibited and strictly penalised (under IIHF rules):** checking from behind, checking to the head/neck area, interference (checking an opponent without the puck), charging, boarding, holding/hitting with the stick, elbowing, kneeing, checking a player in a vulnerable position.
- **Penalty for an illegal check:** minor (2) / major (5) + misconduct (10) or a match penalty — under IIHF rules and at the referee's discretion; for a check involving a risk of injury or causing injury — **a match penalty with a mandatory DC review** (Section 9).

7.2. Types of penalties (under IIHF rules):

PENALTY	TIME	NOTE
Minor	2:00	standard infractions
Bench minor	2:00	served by a skater
Double minor	2+2	e.g. high-sticking causing blood
Major	5:00	+ automatic game misconduct (IIHF)
Misconduct	10:00	player in the penalty box, team not short-handed
Game misconduct	ejection for the rest of the game	+ DC review on accumulation (clause 9.4)
Match penalty	ejection + 5:00 served by a teammate	automatic DC review , suspension of ≥1 game
Penalty shot	—	for fouls under IIHF rules

7.3. Goaltender penalties are served by a skater of the team (under IIHF rules). Coincidental penalties, short-handed mechanics and delayed penalties — under the IIHF Rule Book.

7.4. Fighting. BHC is a body-checking league; emotions and scuffles may happen. The approach is **proportionate**: a single incident does not lead to ejection from the game, while repeat and mass fights are punished severely.

- **Mutual fight (first incident in the game):** each participant receives a **5-minute major penalty (for fighting)**. A single mutual fight does **not** lead to ejection — the players serve 5 minutes and the game continues.
- **Instigator:** additionally a **2-minute minor + 10-minute misconduct**.
- **Game misconduct (ejection):** refusing to stop when ordered by the referee; a player's **second fight** in the game; repeatedly removing the helmet/gloves to fight.
- **Mass infractions (match penalty + suspension + DC review):** third-man-in, leaving the bench to join a fight, a mass brawl.
- **Accumulation:** repeated fights over the season lead to escalating suspensions (Section 9).

8. PLAY-OFFS

8.1. The play-offs are held **over one weekend in January 2027** and conclude the season. The regular season closes before the play-offs begin; the seeding is announced after the last regular-season game. The dates and arena of the play-offs are stated in the season calendar and, once it is published, cannot be moved.

8.2. Qualification. The format depends on the number of season participants (clause 1.3):

- **4 teams — "Final 3":** the **top 3** qualify for the play-offs; 4th place does not qualify.
- **5 teams — "Final Four":** the **top 4** qualify for the play-offs; 5th place does not qualify.

8.3. Bracket (single elimination, one-game knockouts — not series):

"Final 3" (4 teams):

- **1st place** — goes straight to the **Final** (bye).
- **Semi-final:** 2nd vs 3rd — **1 game**.
- **Final:** 1st vs the semi-final winner — **1 game** → Champion.

"Final Four" (5 teams):

- **Semi-finals:** 1st vs 4th and 2nd vs 3rd — **1 game** each.
- **Final:** the semi-final winners — **1 game** → Champion.

Third place: with five teams ("Final Four"), the semi-final losers play a **third-place game** (1 game, on the same weekend). With four teams ("Final 3"), third place goes to the team that lost the semi-final.

8.4. Seeding advantage. The higher-placed team in the standings is the "home" team on the game sheet (choice of jerseys, bench — according to the arena regulations).

8.5. Overtime in the play-offs. There are no draws. If the score is tied after regulation time — **5 minutes of 3-on-3 overtime, until the first goal (sudden death)**. If no goal is scored in overtime — a **shootout** (as in clause 6.2: 3 players, then sudden death) until a winner is determined.

9. DISCIPLINE AND SUSPENSIONS

9.1. The Disciplinary Committee (clause 2.3) reviews all match penalties, fights, abuse of officials, serious infractions and protests. The review takes place during the game round or before the start of the next one.

9.2. Automatic consequences (pending the DC review):

- **Match penalty** → the player misses **at least the next 1 game**; the DC may extend the suspension.
- **2 game misconducts in a season** → a 1-game suspension; each subsequent one — +1 game.

9.3. Sanctions matrix (guideline; the DC may impose stricter sanctions):

INFRACTION	BASE SANCTION
Checking from behind / check to the head / boarding	5 min + match penalty, DC review
Dangerous/dirty check with a risk of injury	match penalty + 1–2 games
Deliberate injury to an opponent	match penalty + 3+ games / until the end of the season
Mutual fight (participant, 1st incident)	5 min, no suspension
Fight instigator	5 + 2 + 10 min; repeat — DC review
Second fight in a game / third man in	match penalty + 1 game
Leaving the bench / mass fight	match penalty + 2–3 games
Abuse of/contact with an official (verbal)	match penalty + 1–2 games
Physical contact with an official	suspension for the season + League review
Unsportsmanlike conduct of a team/coach	bench penalty, DC review

9.4. Accumulation. Penalty minutes and ejections are recorded by the League secretariat; accumulation thresholds (e.g. total minutes) may lead to automatic suspensions — published separately.

9.5. Appeal. A team may appeal a DC decision to the League Commissioner within 48 hours; the Commissioner's decision is final.

10. TIE-BREAKERS (TEAMS LEVEL ON POINTS)

Tie-breakers apply when teams are level on the **total number of points (clause 4.3)**. The criteria are applied in order; as soon as a criterion separates the teams, it is final.

10.1. Two teams level on points:

1. Head-to-head result (games between these two teams; if there were several — the points earned in them, then the goal difference in them);
2. Goal difference in all games;
3. More goals scored in all games;
4. Fewer penalty minutes;
5. Drawing of lots (conducted by the League).

10.2. Three or more teams level on points (IIHF mini-table principle): a sub-group is formed from the games between these teams only:

1. Points in the sub-group games;
2. Goal difference in the sub-group games;
3. Goals scored in the sub-group games;
4. Goal difference in all games of the season;
5. Goals scored in all games of the season;
6. Fewer penalty minutes;
7. Drawing of lots.

(As soon as some of the teams have been separated, the remaining teams restart the procedure from the beginning.)

11. PROTESTS, NO-SHOWS, FORCE MAJEURE

11.1. Game protest. Submitted in writing by the captain/manager **within 2 hours after the game**, citing the relevant clause of the Regulation. Protests concerning the referee's judgement (interpretation of an incident) are not accepted. Reviewed by the DC.

11.2. No-show / insufficient roster. If a team does not show up for a game or has fewer than **5 skaters + 1 goaltender** (clause 3.4) at the scheduled time + a **15-minute** grace period, it receives a **0:5 forfeit** and 0 points; the opponent is credited with a win in regulation time (3 points). Repeated no-shows are reviewed by the Council (up to removal of the team).

11.3. Late arrival. A delay of the start caused by a team — a warning; more than 15 minutes — treated as a no-show (clause 11.2), unless the League decides otherwise due to force majeure.

11.4. Force majeure (ice problems, weather, logistics, shortage of officials): the League may reschedule or rearrange the games of a game round. Rescheduled games are played in the nearest available slot.

11.5. Disruption of a game round. A game round (clause 4.1) brings several games together in one event, so a team failing to arrive for a round is treated separately from a no-show for an individual game.

11.5.1. Notice. A team that cannot attend must notify the League **no later than 21 days** before the first day of the round.

11.5.2. Rescheduling, then forfeit. The procedure is the same for any reason for not arriving — whether the team is at fault or it is force majeure:

- 1. The games are rescheduled.** The League assigns them to the nearest game round with a free slot, but **no later than the last day of the regular season**.
- 2. If there is no free slot before the end of the regular season**, or the team **does not arrive for the rescheduled games either**, they are recorded as **0:5 forfeits** against it, and the opponents receive 3 points for each.

The difference between fault and force majeure lies only in money, not in results:

REASON	FINANCIAL CONSEQUENCES
Team at fault (failed to assemble a roster, refused to travel, late notice)	The team's share of the ice for the round is not refunded ; additional ice for the rescheduled games is paid by the team; a repeat — Council review up to removal of the team
Force majeure (border closure, flight cancellation, weather, illness in the squad — documented)	The ice share is refunded minus the League's actual expenses; additional ice for the rescheduled games is split between the League and the team

11.5.3. Reserve schedule. A game round **is not cancelled** if a team fails to arrive. For each round the League prepares in advance a reserve set of games between the remaining teams, occupying the same ice slots. Reserve games are played as regular championship games and count in the standings. This keeps the round for spectators, the broadcast and partners, and the paid ice is not wasted.

11.5.4. Payment in advance. The participation fee is paid **in full** by the deadline announced by the League, **before the team's first game**: the ice is booked and paid for by the League in advance, regardless of whether the teams actually attend.

11.6. Withdrawal/disqualification of a team. If a team is withdrawn during the season, **the results of games already played stand**. All of its remaining games are recorded as **0:5 forfeits**, and the opponents receive 3 points for each. If the withdrawal happens early in the season and this procedure clearly distorts the standings, the Team Representatives Council may take a different decision (clause 1.5).

12. CODE OF CONDUCT (FAIR PLAY)

12.1. Respect for opponents, officials, staff and spectators is mandatory.

12.2. Racist or discriminatory abuse and aggression off the ice are gross violations, reviewed by the DC/League, up to suspension.

12.3. Alcohol and prohibited substances are banned in the playing area and locker rooms.

12.4. Players and teams represent the League in the media — constructively and appropriately.

APPENDICES (PUBLISHED SEPARATELY)

- **A.** Season calendar 2026/27: dates and arenas of the game rounds.
- **B.** Arena regulations (benches, locker rooms, access).
- **C.** Ice resurfacing and slot procedure for a game day.
- **D.** Registration form and game sheet template.

SOURCES (THIS REGULATION IS BASED ON):

- **IIHF Official Rule Book 2025/26** — https://blob.iihf.com/iihf-media/iihfmvc/media/contentimages/4_sport/officiating/rule_book/25_26/2025-26_iihf_rulebook_19052025-v1.pdf (playing rules, penalties, overtime/shootout)
- **IIHF Sport Regulations (in force since 09.10.2023)** — https://blob.iihf.com/iihf-media/iihfmvc/media/downloads/regulations/2024/2024_iihf_sport_regulations_20240409.pdf (3-2-1-0 points, tie-breakers, registration)
- **USA Hockey — Official Playing Rules 2025-29** — https://cdn2.sportngin.com/attachments/document/945a-3442848/2025-29_USAH_Playing_Rules.pdf (reference for adult amateur rules, discipline)

